Physical Appearance and Elections: An Inequality Perspective

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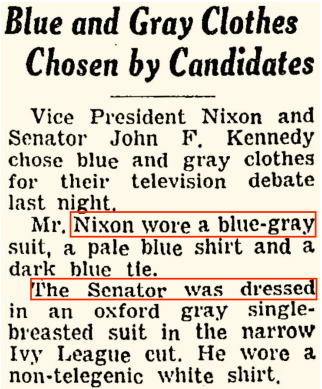
TV, Looks and Political Branding

- During the 1950s and the 1960s, the TV gets massively introduced in American homes.
- This opened up new possibilities for **political campaigning**.



TV, Looks and Political Branding

- In 1960 was the **first televised presidential debate**: Nixon vs. Kennedy.
- For the first time, make up, posture, clothing (**physical appearance!**) began to matter.



Blue and Gray Clothes Chosen by Candidates

Vice President Nixon and Senator John F. Kennedy chose blue and gray clothes for their television debate last night.

Mr. Nixon wore a blue-gray suit, a pale blue shirt and a dark blue tie.

The Senator was dressed in an oxford gray single-breasted suit in the narrow Ivy League cut. He wore a non-telegenic white shirt.

The Times (London 1960).

Nixon-Kennedy 1960 Debate

- Nixon's "five-o'clock shadow" negatively affected his evaluation.

  Mattes et. al (2010).

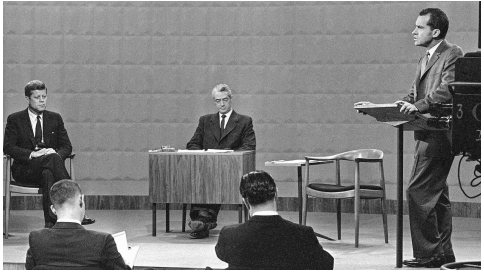


Nixon-Kennedy 1960 Debate

- Nixon's "five-o'clock shadow" negatively affected his evaluation.

  Mattes et. al (2010).

- Nixon's posture didn't look "presidential."



Nixon-Kennedy 1960 Debate

- Nixon's "five-o'clock shadow" negatively affected his evaluation.

  Mattes et. al (2010).

- Nixon's posture didn't look "presidential."
- Nixon was all sweaty.

  Stockemer and Praino (2019).



Nixon-Kennedy 1960 Debate



Radio listeners thought Nixon would win, while TV-watchers though Kennedy would.

Good-looking Candidates do Better in Elections

- Better-looking candidates are more likely to win elections.
- We know that "**beautiful is good**" (Dion et al., 1972) and that "**voters vote beautiful**" (Efrain and Patterson, 1974).



"What Are Good-Looking Candidates?" (Stockemer and Praino, 2019)

What About Wealthy-looking or Poor-looking Candidates?

- While we know that better-looking candidates win more often, we're rather ignorant about the effects of looking poor/wealthy on the probability of winning elections.
- This questions is relevant because it touches upon issues of perceived social stratification and voting choices.

Inequality Perspective: Social Stratification and Elections

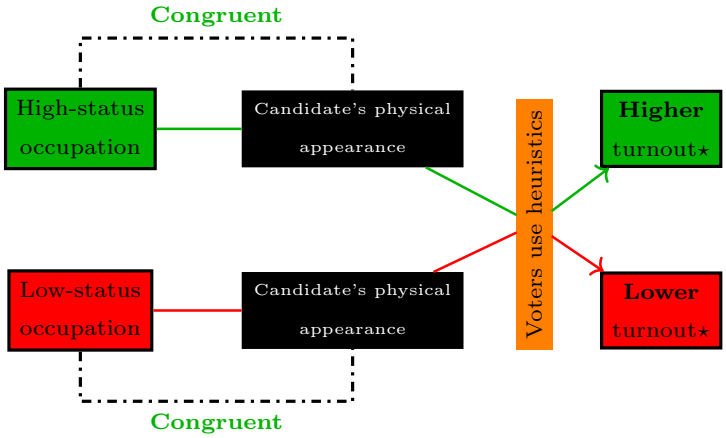
- **Identify** that the literature *only* looks at candidate attractiveness, which is just *one* dimension of physical appearance.
- **Beyond attractiveness** and explore the degree in which a candidate's **social class** affects his/her voting.
- **Empirics**: we exploit a novel data set of candidate's physical appearance in the context of the 2017 Finnish Municipal Elections.
- **(*Uncomfortable*) results**: Finns systematically...
  1. Vote for upper-class candidates.
  2. Punish working-class candidates, specially female candidates.

Political Psychology: Heuristics

- A candidate's **physical appearance** is "the most important" (Lau & Redlawsk 2001) and the "most obvious and accessible" (Dion et al. 1972) *heuristic* available to voters (Stockemer & Praino 2017).
- **Heuristics** are cognitive devices that allow reasonable voting decision making with minimal effort (Lau & Redlawsk 2001 and Tversky & Kahneman 1973).
- Thus, "voters vote beautiful" (Efrain & Patterson 1974) because attractive candidates "are more likely to be attributed the qualities associated with successful politicians" (Stockemer & Praino 2019).

Status Expectations Theory

- **Status Expectations Theory**: physical attractiveness is considered a similar status characteristic as gender or occupation.
  - ✓ For ex., attractive people are 'better' and more 'capable' (Webster & Driskell 1983).
- In this paper we broaden this idea to physical appearance-based cues of occupation as a status characteristic.
  - ✓ We argue that information about a candidate's occupation combined with his/her physical appearance function as cue of status, in turn affecting his/her likelihood of winning an election.


Congruent
High-status occupation
Candidate's physical appearance
Voters use heuristics
Higher turnout⋆
Low-status occupation
Candidate's physical appearance
Lower turnout⋆
Congruent
⋆Particularly for women

Finland as a Hard Case

- We follow a "**least-likely case design**" (Levy 2008). Finland has been consistently considered as:
  - A democratic (Polity-V).
  - An economic egalitarian (Waltl 2022).
  - A gender egalitarian.
  - A social-mobility prone country (Erola 2009).
- Thus, it should be **hard to find** a correlation between class-congruent use of status symbols and voting.

...and yet, we *do*.

Municipal Elections in Finland

- **Municipal Elections**: held every four years to elect councilors of the different municipalities (N=293).
- **D'Hondt**: candidates run in party lists. Sits are filled with lists of candidates proportionally.
- **Municipalities**: provide daycare, health, education, water, waste management, among others.

Campaigns: Plain, Simple and Fair

- **"Low-information" elections**: most voters get exposed to only the official candidate pictures shown in the posters.

  (Berggren et al. 2010 & 2017).

- **Public information**: shown in city centers, bus stops, *and* voting booths!
- Municipalities *must* provide the *same* number of poster slots for all parties.



Average Poster Displaying Candidates Faces in Finnish Elections

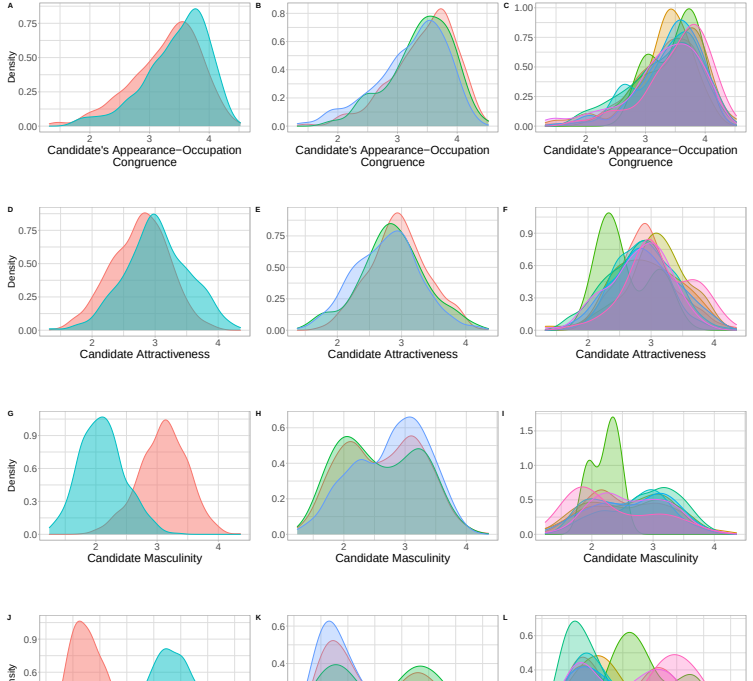
2017 Municipal Elections: Candidate Data

- **Ministry of Justice**: candidate's pictures, district, occupation and voting data.
- **Sample**: Universe 33,618, possible 10,000, randomly selected **1,500 candidate photographs**.
- **Occupation**: European Socio-economic Classification, recoded each candidate's occupation (upper, middle and working class).

Novel Raters Data

- **Sample**: able to collect data from 7,920 randomly selected Finnish-speaking Finns.
- **Task**: participants evaluated a random sample of candidate photographs according to five items (N∼50).
- **Items**:
  1. **Occupation-Congruent Appearance.**
  2. **Attractiveness.**
  3. **Masculinity.**
  4. **Femininity.**
- **Avoiding recognition**: proprietary software designed to avoid assigning candidates running in the same district of the rater's.

▸ show table with items


A
B
C
D
E
F
G
H
I
J
K
L
Density
Candidate's Appearance−Occupation Congruence
Candidate Attractiveness
Candidate Masculinity

Functional Form and Model

$$
\begin{aligned}
Y_i = \text{Votes}_i \sim \texttt{Poisson} \\
\text{Votes}_i = \beta_0 + \\
\beta_1 \text{Occupation-congruent Appearance} \times \text{Social Class} + \\
\beta_2 \text{Age} + \\
\gamma 1 \text{Party} + \\
\gamma 2 \text{City}
\end{aligned}
$$

- **Also control for**: Attractiveness, Masculinity and Femininity.
- **Partition the data** (full, men & women).

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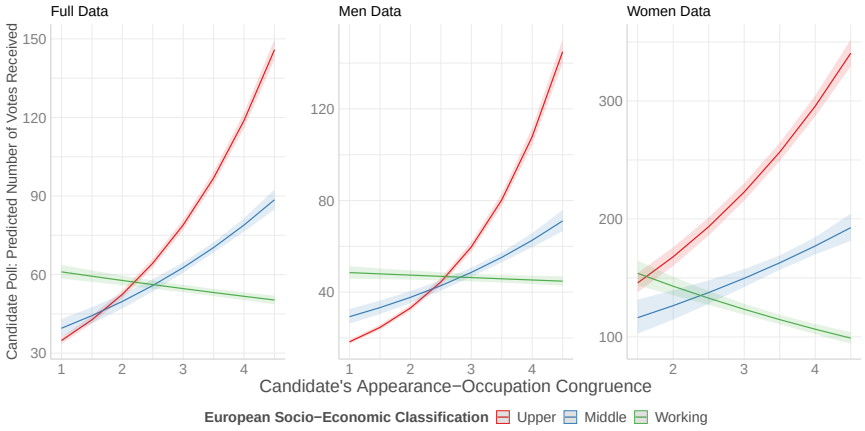
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	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12
	Men	Women	Full	Full	Full	Men	Women	Men	Women	Men	Women	Full
Intercept	4.49 ***	2.58 ***	6.17 ***	2.11 ***	4.27 ***	2.15 ***	-0.25 **	3.24 ***	2.50 ***	2.98 ***	0.17	2.80 ***
	(0.05)	(0.08)	(0.07)	(0.05)	(0.05)	(0.05)	(0.09)	(0.08)	(0.08)	(0.08)	(0.09)	(0.08)
Appearance-Occupation Congruence	0.41 ***	0.59 ***	0.28 ***	0.25 ***	0.42 ***	0.26 ***	0.37 ***	0.22 ***	0.59 ***	0.28 ***	0.37 ***	0.24 ***
	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)
Middle Class	0.30 ***	0.81 ***	-0.05	0.41 ***	0.23 ***	0.31 ***	0.54 ***	0.12	0.77 ***	0.18	0.75 ***	0.16
	(0.06)	(0.08)	(0.11)	(0.06)	(0.06)	(0.06)	(0.08)	(0.11)	(0.08)	(0.11)	(0.08)	(0.11)
Working Class	1.03 ***	1.59 ***	0.70 ***	0.49 ***	1.07 ***	0.58 ***	0.95 ***	0.23 ***	1.59 ***	0.32 ***	0.86 ***	0.19 **
	(0.03)	(0.04)	(0.07)	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.04)	(0.07)	(0.04)	(0.07)	(0.04)	(0.07)
Age	-0.02 ***	-0.01 ***	-0.03 ***	-0.00 ***	-0.02 ***	-0.01 ***	0.00 ***	-0.01 ***	-0.01 ***	-0.02 ***	0.01 ***	-0.01 ***
	(0.00)	(0.00)	(0.00)	(0.00)	(0.00)	(0.00)	(0.00)	(0.00)	(0.00)	(0.00)	(0.00)	(0.00)
Appearance-Occupation Congruence × Middle Class												

Main Results



Main Results

- **Male & female** candidates:
  - ✓ Candidates that show *higher degrees of congruence* between physical appearance and occupation do better.
  - ✓ Candidates that look-like and also perform *upper-class occupations* do best in elections.
- **Female** candidates: stronger effects.
  - Systematic electoral penalty when they **look-like** and also **perform working-class occupations**.
  - Systematic electoral premium when they **look-like** and also **perform white-collar occupations**.

Main Takeaways

- ✓ Considered **the use of heuristics in elections** and the concept of **"status" in expectation states theory**.
- ✓ Selected the ***unlikely* case** of the 2017 Finnish Municipal Elections.
- ✓ Exploited a **novel representative data set** on candidates physical appearances.
- ✓ Proposed an alternative explanation for voting not based on attractiveness but on occupation-congruent appearance and social stratification.

Thank you

All feedback is welcomed!

Raters Data: Questions and Answer Set

Sample	Attribute	Question	Answer Set
1	Occupation-Congruent Appearance	To what extent does this person respond to your image of someone working in [occupation]?	5=Perfectly responds to my image, 4=Responds well to my image, 3=Somewhat responds to my image, 2=Does not respond to my image well, 1=Does not respond to my image at all.
2	Attractiveness	In your opinion, how attractive does this person look, as compared to others of the same age and gender?	5=very attractive, 4=more attractive than the average, 3=average, 2=below average, 1=well below average (Griffin and Langois 2006; Bono et al. 2017; Tu, Gilbert and Bono 2021)
3	Masculinity	To what extent do you think this person looks masculine, as compared to others of the same age and gender?	1=not masculine at all, to 5=very masculine (e.g., Hoss et al. 2005).
4	Femininity	To what extent do you think this person looks feminine, as compared to others of the same age and gender?	1=not feminine at all, to 5=very feminine.